Audit Clinical Evidence

COVER LETTER | ACE2026001

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TO Professor José Maria Soares-Jr., Editor-in-Chief, *Clinics*, Elsevier
clinics@hc.fm.usp.br

RE **Audit report ACE2026001 on an article published in Clinics**

2019c Abdelbasset, W. K., Alqahtani, B. A., Elshehawy, A. A., Tantawy, S. A., Elnegamy, T. E., & Kamel, D. M. (2019). Examining the impacts of 12 weeks of low to moderate-intensity aerobic exercise on depression status in patients with systolic congestive heart failure. A randomized controlled study. *Clinics*, 74, e1017. DOI 10.6061/clinics/2019/e1017

Dear Professor Soares-Jr.,

Audit Clinical Evidence (ACE) is an independent initiative that publishes reproducible audits of clinical research. We write to make you aware of our audit of the article cited above. The report, ACE2026001, is published on the ACE website and permanently archived with a DOI. A copy is enclosed.

Report `https://auditclinicalevidence.org/reports/ACE2026001`
Archive `https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.22861278`

The audit finds serious errors in the article. The trial data in this article are duplicated across three published studies, the other two published in *Medicine*. The means and standard deviations reported for the primary outcome, the PHQ-9, could not have come from a real data set. Furthermore, the three articles report different author contribution statements and three consecutive ethics approval numbers for what appears to be one trial. The reported effect sizes are extreme and contaminate later meta-analyses of exercise for depression. In total, the report documents 29 errors or integrity concerns across the three articles. Every number in the report is computed from the articles' published values with code that accompanies the report, so each finding can be checked independently. On the basis of these findings, ACE recommends retraction of the article. The decision belongs to the journal.

We ask that the journal assess the report under its research integrity procedures and the COPE guidelines, and let us know the outcome. ACE has not contacted the authors. We would welcome a response from the authors and will publish any response alongside the report, in full or quoted in part, as described in our correspondence policy at https://auditclinicalevidence.org/disclaimers.

ACE records its correspondence with journals on a public page, https://auditclinicalevidence.org/correspondence, which shows the date this letter was sent, the date of any reply, and the journal's decision. If this letter should go to a different office, we would be grateful for the correct address.

Sincerely,

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on behalf of Audit Clinical Evidence